boss, police commissioner Rasheed Khan (Mohit Takalkar), Kennedy's attitude towards violence is efficient and almost bureaucratic. "His emotional detachment is very unsettling."

Walking the acting tightrope, Bhat plays him with vacant-eyed apathy while exuding both menace and vulnerability. "I had to strip away all rules of external performance. After understanding Kennedy's psychology, I had to find ways to 'show' stillness. This involved slowing down my breathing and controlling how much I blink." The film is Bhat's third collaboration with Kashyap, whom he describes as 'one of a kind'. "Anurag doesn't overdirect or micro-manage. He trusts that I will find the emotional truth of the character. While that freedom is intimidating, it also pushes my performances to be honest rather than decorative."

Bhat, who started filming a new Netflix series on Holi this year, currently has three films in post-production. There's an untitled love story with Dia Mirza that was shot in Nainital, and Madhur Bhandarkar's *The Wives*. "I have also completed an Indo-American production titled *Lost & Found in Kumbh*, which was shot during the 2025 Prayagraj Maha Kumbh," he says. ■

—Karishma Upadhyay



THEATRE ▼

Spooky Does It

Aadyam Theatre's eighth season begins with the supernatural thriller *Ankahi* in the capital

Aadyam Theatre is all set to give Delhiites a dose of chills and thrills when it showcases its eighth season in the capital later this month. The theatre initiative by the Aditya Birla Group is kickstarting their new season with the supernatural thriller *Ankahi*, a genre they are exploring for the first time. Directed by Vikranth Pawar, *Ankahi* is the Hindi adaptation of Susan Hill's classic horror story *The Woman in Black*.

Pawar, who has earlier directed the fairy tale *Beauty and the Beast*, bringing the Disney Broadway-style musical to India for the first time, says that the story of *Ankahi* is as engrossing as the method of its telling. "This is one of those rare plays that has a really interesting and experimental format, but the sheer canvas of the story lends itself to being staged in a large proscenium," he says.

> The plot revolves around a middle-aged lawyer **afflicted with a haunting secret,** who turns to theatre to cope with the past

The plot revolves around Sandeepan Chauhan, a middle-aged lawyer, afflicted with a haunting secret from his past, who resorts to a young, sceptical actor to turn his tryst with horror into a staged performance. As the performance takes shape, the audience gets immersed in Chauhan's past, where a simple, legal matter to settle the estate of a deceased woman, Fatima Ilyas, turns into a nightmare. "*Ankahi* blurs the line between reality and the paranormal. You want to find out more at every turn," says Pawar, adding that legends and beliefs, loss and grief, hope and responsibility are some of the themes explored in the play. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

Ankahi *will be staged at Kamani Auditorium, Delhi on Mar. 28 and 29*